Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

FREE GUIDE

فَاصْبِرْ كَمَا صَبَرَ أُولُو الْعَزْمِ مِنَ الرُّسُلِ

"So be patient, as the messengers of firm resolve were patient." (al-Aḥqāf 46:35)

Ūlu al-ʿAzm

The five messengers of firm resolve: Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, ʿĪsā and Muḥammad ﷺ.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Allah sent prophets and messengers to every nation, all calling to the same truth: worship Allah alone. Among them, five are singled out in the Qur'an and honoured above the rest: **Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, ʿĪsā and Muḥammad** (peace and blessings be upon them all). They are called **Ūlu al-ʿAzm min ar-Rusul**, the messengers of firm resolve.

Each of them faced enormous trials: mockery, exile, fire, tyrants, betrayal and war. Each held firm, trusted Allah, and kept calling people to Him with patience. Allah told our Prophet ﷺ to follow their example:

> فَاصْبِرْ كَمَا صَبَرَ أُولُو الْعَزْمِ مِنَ الرُّسُلِ وَلَا تَسْتَعْجِل لَّهُمْ
>
> **"So be patient, as the messengers of firm resolve were patient, and do not seek to hasten [punishment] for them."**
>
> Al-Aḥqāf 46:35.

How this book tells their stories

The stories here are taken from the **Qur'an** and from **authentic ḥadīth**, with the verse or source given each time. The Qur'an tells these stories for guidance, not for entertainment, so we follow what it tells and do not fill the gaps with uncertain tales.

Many popular stories about the earlier prophets come from the Isrāʾīliyyāt (reports from the People of the Book). Where the Qur'an and Sunnah are silent, this book is silent too. No reliable dates are known for the earlier prophets, so none are given.

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How to read this book

1 Read **one messenger at a time**, with a muṣḥaf beside you. Open the verses mentioned and read them in the Qur'an itself.

2 Memorise **one duʿāʾ from each messenger**. They are gathered on one page near the end.

3 Use the **comparison table and the self-test** to fix what you have read.

4 **Teachers and parents:** each chapter can be told as a story in two or three sittings, with the "Lessons for us" as the discussion.

Part 1 Who are Ūlu al-ʿAzm?

The meaning of the name

ʿ**Azm** means firm resolve: a determination that does not break under pressure, joined with patience and steadfastness. **Ūlu al-ʿAzm** means "those who possess firm resolve". All prophets were patient and resolute, but these five carried the heaviest missions, faced the greatest opposition, and showed the greatest steadfastness.

The verses that name them

Most scholars, among them Ibn ʿAbbās and Qatādah as reported in the books of tafsīr, hold that Ūlu al-ʿAzm are these five, because Allah names them together in two places:

> وَإِذْ أَخَذْنَا مِنَ النَّبِيِّينَ مِيثَاقَهُمْ وَمِنكَ وَمِن نُّوحٍ وَإِبْرَاهِيمَ وَمُوسَىٰ وَعِيسَى ابْنِ مَرْيَمَ ۖ وَأَخَذْنَا مِنْهُم مِّيثَاقًا غَلِيظًا
>
> **"And [remember] when We took from the prophets their covenant, and from you, and from Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā and ʿĪsā son of Maryam. We took from them a solemn covenant."**
>
> Al-Aḥzāb 33:7.

And in ash-Shūrā 42:13, Allah tells us that the religion He ordained for us is what He enjoined upon Nūḥ, revealed to Muḥammad ﷺ, and enjoined upon Ibrāhīm, Mūsā and ʿĪsā. Some scholars held other views about who the Ūlu al-ʿAzm are, but this is the best known and the view of the majority.

The Day of Judgement

The rank of these five appears clearly in the great ḥadīth of intercession. On the Day of Judgement, when people are in unbearable distress, they will go to Ādam, then to **Nūḥ** ("you are the first of the messengers to the people of the earth, and Allah called you a grateful servant"), then to **Ibrāhīm** ("you are the prophet of Allah and His friend"), then to **Mūsā** ("Allah favoured you with His messages and His speech"), then to **ʿĪsā** ("His word which He conveyed to Maryam and a spirit from Him"). Each sends them on, until they come to **Muḥammad** ﷺ, who prostrates before his Lord and is given permission to intercede (al-Bukhārī 4712, Muslim 194).

Brothers with one religion

الْأَنْبِيَاءُ إِخْوَةٌ لِعَلَّاتٍ، أُمَّهَاتُهُمْ شَتَّى وَدِينُهُمْ وَاحِدٌ

“The prophets are brothers from one father: their mothers are different, but their religion is one.”

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3443) and Muslim (2365). Their laws differed in details; their belief, tawḥīd, was one.

One message, five messengers

شَرَعَ لَكُم مِّنَ الدِّينِ مَا وَصَّىٰ بِهِ نُوحًا وَالَّذِي أَوْحَيْنَا إِلَيْكَ وَمَا وَصَّيْنَا بِهِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَمُوسَىٰ وَعِيسَىٰ

“He has ordained for you of religion what He enjoined upon Nūḥ, and what We revealed to you, and what We enjoined upon Ibrāhīm, Mūsā and ʿĪsā.” (ash-Shūrā 42:13)

1 — Nūḥ (نُوحٌ)

SENT TO
His people

SCRIPTURE
Not named in the Qur’an

2 — Ibrāhīm (إِبْرَاهِيمُ)

SENT TO
His people, then his family in Shām and Makkah

SCRIPTURE
The ṣuḥuf (scrolls) of Ibrāhīm

3 — Mūsā (مُوسَى)

SENT TO
Pharaoh and the Children of Israel

SCRIPTURE
The Tawrāh

4 — ʿĪsā (عِيسَى ابْنُ مَرْيَمَ)

SENT TO
The Children of Israel

SCRIPTURE
The Injīl

5 — Muḥammad (مُحَمَّدٌ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ)

SENT TO
All mankind and the jinn

SCRIPTURE
The Qur’an

Their shared message: worship Allah alone, establish the religion, and do not split into factions

01

ŪLU AL-ʿAZM · 01

نُوحٌ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

ʿABDAN SHAKŪRĀ · A GRATEFUL SERVANT

Nūḥ

Nūḥ, peace be upon him

The first messenger to the people of the earth · his people

950	1st	71
years calling his people (al-ʿAnkabūt 29:14)	messenger sent to the people of the earth	the sūrah that carries his name

Messenger 1 Nūḥ: at a glance

Title	**ʿAbdan shakūrā**, “a truly grateful servant” (al-Isrāʾ 17:3); the first messenger to the people of the earth
Sent to	His people, who had begun worshipping idols
Length of his call	950 years (al-ʿAnkabūt 29:14)
Main trial	Rejection by almost all his people, including his own son and his wife
Sign	The ark and the flood
In the Qur’an	Sūrat Nūḥ (71), and in Hūd, al-Aʿrāf, al-Muʾminūn, ash-Shuʿarāʾ and al-Qamar

How idol worship began

After Ādam, people worshipped Allah alone for generations. Then idolatry crept in. Ibn ʿAbbās explained that Wadd, Suwāʿ, Yaghūth, Yaʿūq and Nasr, the idols of Nūḥ’s people named in Sūrat Nūḥ (71:23), were names of righteous men. When they died, Shayṭān whispered to their people to set up statues in their gatherings to remember them. Those people did not worship them, but when they passed away and knowledge was forgotten, the statues were worshipped (al-Bukhārī, 4920). So Allah sent Nūḥ, the first messenger to the people of the earth.

950 years of calling

Nūḥ called his people to worship Allah alone for nine hundred and fifty years (al-ʿAnkabūt 29:14). He used every method: by night and by day, in public and in private (Nūḥ 71:5–9). He reminded them of Allah’s blessings and promised them that forgiveness would bring rain, wealth and children:

> فَقُلْتُ اسْتَغْفِرُوا رَبَّكُمْ إِنَّهُ كَانَ غَفَّارًا
>
> **“I said: Ask forgiveness of your Lord. Indeed, He is ever Forgiving.”**
>
> Nūḥ 71:10, followed by the promise of rain, wealth, children, gardens and rivers (71:11–12).

They put their fingers in their ears, covered themselves with their garments and grew more arrogant (71:7). The leaders mocked his followers as the lowest of people (Hūd 11:27). Only a few believed (Hūd 11:40).

The ark and the flood

After centuries, Allah revealed to Nūḥ that no more of his people would believe except those who already had (Hūd 11:36), and commanded him to build the ark under His watch. Each time the leaders passed by, they mocked him, and he replied that they too would be mocked (Hūd 11:38).

Then the command came: water burst from the earth and poured from the sky, and Nūḥ carried in the ark a pair of every kind, his family except those against whom the word had gone forth, and the believers (Hūd 11:40).

One of his sons stayed behind. Nūḥ called to him with a father's love:

> يَا بُنَيَّ ارْكَب مَّعَنَا وَلَا تَكُن مَّعَ الْكَافِرِينَ
>
> **"O my son, come aboard with us and do not be with the disbelievers."**
>
> Hūd 11:42. His son said he would take refuge on a mountain; Nūḥ replied: "There is no protector today from the decree of Allah, except for whom He has mercy." And the waves came between them (11:43).

When the flood ended, the ark came to rest on al-Jūdī (Hūd 11:44). Nūḥ asked his Lord about his son, and Allah told him that his son was not of his family, because his deeds were not righteous (Hūd 11:45–46). Nūḥ's wife also disbelieved, and Allah gives her as an example of those whom closeness to a prophet did not save (at-Taḥrīm 66:10).

His testimony on the Day of Judgement

The Prophet ﷺ said that on the Day of Judgement Nūḥ will be asked whether he conveyed the message, and he will say yes. His people will deny it, and Allah will ask Nūḥ who his witnesses are. He will say: "Muḥammad and his Ummah," and this Ummah will testify that he conveyed it (al-Bukhārī, 3339), as in al-Baqarah 2:143.

Lessons for us

1	**Keep calling, whatever the response.** Nūḥ did not stop after a year, a decade or a century.
2	**Guidance is from Allah.** Even a prophet could not guide his son or his wife. Our duty is to convey with wisdom; results are with Allah.
3	**Guard tawḥīd from small beginnings.** Idolatry started with statues "to remember" righteous people.
4	**Istighfār opens doors** of rain, provision and children (71:10–12).
5	**Be grateful.** Allah praised Nūḥ as "a truly grateful servant".

02

ŪLU AL-ʿAZM · 02

إِبْرَاهِيمُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

KHALĪLULLĀH · THE FRIEND OF ALLAH

Ibrāhīm

Ibrāhīm, peace be upon him

The friend of Allah, father of the prophets · Iraq, Shām and Makkah

1
man who was a whole nation (an-Naḥl 16:120)

2
prophet sons: Ismāʿīl and Isḥāq

14
the sūrah that carries his name

Messenger 2 Ibrāhīm: at a glance

Title	**Khalīlullāh**, the close friend of Allah (an-Nisāʾ 4:125); the father of the prophets
Sent to	His people in Iraq, who worshipped idols and heavenly bodies; he later emigrated to Shām and settled his son Ismāʿīl in Makkah
Scripture	The ṣuḥuf (scrolls) of Ibrāhīm (al-Aʿlā 87:19)
Main trials	His father's rejection, the fire, leaving his family in a barren valley, the command to sacrifice his son
Sons	Ismāʿīl (from Hājar) and Isḥāq (from Sārah), both prophets
In the Qur'an	Sūrat Ibrāhīm (14), and in al-Baqarah, al-Anʿām, Maryam, al-Anbiyāʾ, aṣ-Ṣāffāt and many others

Calling his father

Ibrāhīm grew up among a people who carved idols, and his own father Āzar made them. He called his father with great gentleness, beginning each sentence with "O my father" (yā abati), explaining that idols neither hear nor see nor benefit (Maryam 19:41–45). His father threatened to stone him and told him to leave. Ibrāhīm replied: "Peace be upon you. I will ask my Lord to forgive you" (Maryam 19:47).

The stars, the moon and the sun

To show his people the falsehood of worshipping heavenly bodies, Ibrāhīm reasoned with them openly. When a star rose he said "This is my lord", and when it set he said "I do not love those that set." He did the same with the moon and the sun, then declared: "I have turned my face to the One who created the heavens and the earth, inclining to the truth, and I am not of those who associate partners with Allah" (al-Anʿām 6:76–79).

The idols and the fire

While his people were away at a festival, Ibrāhīm broke their idols into pieces except the largest, so they would turn to it. When they asked who had done this, he told them to ask the idols, if they could speak. Shamed, they admitted the idols cannot speak, and he said: "Do you worship besides Allah what neither benefits you nor harms you?" (al-Anbiyāʾ 21:58–67). They decided to burn him alive, and built a great fire. Allah said:

قُلْنَا يَا نَارُ كُونِي بَرْدًا وَسَلَامًا عَلَىٰ إِبْرَاهِيمَ

“We said: O fire, be coolness and safety upon Ibrāhīm.”

Al-Anbiyāʾ 21:69.

Ibrāhīm also debated a tyrant king who claimed to give life and death. Ibrāhīm said: “Allah brings the sun from the east, so bring it from the west,” and the disbeliever was left speechless (al-Baqarah 2:258).

Emigration and the valley of Makkah

Ibrāhīm left his people for the sake of Allah, saying: “I am going to my Lord; He will guide me” (aṣ-Ṣāffāt 37:99), with his wife Sārah and his nephew Lūṭ, who believed in him (al-ʿAnkabūt 29:26). Later, by Allah’s command, he took his wife **Hājar** and their baby **Ismāʿīl** to a barren valley with no water and no people: the valley of Makkah. As he turned to leave, Hājar asked him again and again why he was leaving them. Then she asked:

آللَّهُ الَّذِي أَمَرَكَ بِهَذَا؟ قَالَ: نَعَمْ. قَالَتْ: إِذَنْ لَا يُضَيِّعُنَا

“Is it Allah who commanded you to do this?” He said: “Yes.” She said: “Then He will not abandon us.”

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3364), from Ibn ʿAbbās.

When the water ran out, Hājar ran seven times between the hills of aṣ-Ṣafā and al-Marwah searching for help, and Allah sent the angel Jibrīl, who struck the ground, and the water of **Zamzam** gushed out (al-Bukhārī, 3364). The Prophet ﷺ said: “That is why people walk between them” in Ḥajj and ʿUmrah.

The greatest test: the sacrifice

When Ismāʿīl was old enough to walk with his father, Ibrāhīm saw in a dream, and the dreams of prophets are revelation, that he was sacrificing his son. He told Ismāʿīl, and the son answered with the same faith as his father:

قَالَ يَا أَبَتِ افْعَلْ مَا تُؤْمَرُ ۖ سَتَجِدُنِي إِن شَاءَ اللَّهُ مِنَ الصَّابِرِينَ

“He said: O my father, do as you are commanded. You will find me, if Allah wills, among the patient.”

Aṣ-Ṣāffāt 37:102. When both submitted, Allah called out that Ibrāhīm had fulfilled the vision, and ransomed Ismāʿīl with a great sacrifice (37:103–107). This is remembered every ʿĪd al-Aḍḥā.

Building the Kaʿbah

Ibrāhīm and Ismāʿīl raised the foundations of the House in Makkah, praying as they worked:

رَبَّنَا تَقَبَّلْ مِنَّا ۖ إِنَّكَ أَنتَ السَّمِيعُ الْعَلِيمُ

“Our Lord, accept [this] from us. Indeed, You are the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing.”

Al-Baqarah 2:127. In the same duʿāʾ they asked Allah to raise from their descendants a messenger who would recite His verses and teach the Book and wisdom (2:129): that messenger is Muḥammad ﷺ.

Allah commanded Ibrāhīm to call people to Ḥajj (al-Ḥajj 22:27), made him an imām for mankind (al-Baqarah 2:124), and commanded our Prophet ﷺ to follow his way: “Follow the religion of Ibrāhīm, inclining to the truth” (an-Naḥl 16:123). The Prophet ﷺ said Ibrāhīm will be the first person clothed on the Day of Resurrection (al-Bukhārī, 3349).

Lessons for us

1	**Speak to parents with gentleness**, even when they are wrong: “O my father… peace be upon you.”
2	**Use reason and clear argument** to show the truth, as he did with the stars and the idols.
3	**Trust Allah completely.** “Then He will not abandon us,” said Hājar, and Zamzam still flows.
4	**Submit to Allah’s command** even when it is the hardest thing; Ismāʿīl’s answer shows how a righteous upbringing bears fruit.
5	**Ask Allah to accept your deeds**, even while doing the greatest of them.

03

ŪLU AL-ʿAZM · 03

مُوسَى عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

KALĪMULLĀH · THE ONE ALLAH SPOKE TO

Mūsā

Mūsā ibn ʿImrān, peace be upon him

Sent to Pharaoh and the Children of Israel · Egypt and Sinai

130+
times he is named in the Qur'an

9
clear signs given to him (al-Isrāʾ 17:101)

40
nights of his appointment with his Lord

Messenger 3 Mūsā: at a glance

Title	**Kalīmullāh**, the one to whom Allah spoke directly: “And Allah spoke to Mūsā with [direct] speech” (an-Nisāʾ 4:164)
Sent to	Pharaoh and his chiefs, and the Children of Israel (Banū Isrāʾīl)
Scripture	The Tawrāh
Helper	His brother Hārūn, also a prophet
Signs	Nine clear signs (al-Isrāʾ 17:101), including the staff and the shining hand, and the parting of the sea
In the Qur’an	The most frequently mentioned prophet, named more than 130 times; his story is told in al-Baqarah, al-Aʿrāf, Ṭā Hā, ash-Shuʿarāʾ, al-Qaṣaṣ and many more

Born in danger

Pharaoh was a tyrant who divided the people of Egypt, enslaved the Children of Israel, and killed their newborn sons (al-Qaṣaṣ 28:4). When Mūsā was born, Allah inspired his mother: “Nurse him, and when you fear for him, cast him into the river, and do not fear or grieve. We will return him to you and make him one of the messengers” (al-Qaṣaṣ 28:7). The river carried the baby to Pharaoh’s own palace, where Pharaoh’s wife said: “A comfort of the eye for me and for you; do not kill him” (28:9). Mūsā refused every nurse until his sister guided them to his own mother, and so Allah returned him to her (28:12–13).

Flight to Madyan

As a young man, Mūsā tried to help a man of his people in a fight and struck an Egyptian, who died, though Mūsā had not intended to kill him. He sought Allah’s forgiveness (al-Qaṣaṣ 28:15–16), and when he learned the chiefs were plotting to kill him, he fled to Madyan. Alone, exhausted and a stranger there, he helped two young women water their flock, then sat in the shade and prayed:

> رَبِّ إِنِّي لِمَا أَنزَلْتَ إِلَيَّ مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَقِيرٌ
>
> **“My Lord, I am in need of whatever good You send down to me.”**
>
> Al-Qaṣaṣ 28:24. Soon after, one of the women came walking with modesty to invite him to her father, who gave him work and his daughter in marriage (28:25–28).

The call at the valley of Ṭuwā

After years in Madyan, Mūsā was travelling with his family when he saw a fire on the side of Mount Ṭūr. There Allah spoke to him: “Indeed, I am Allah; there is no god except Me, so worship Me and establish prayer for My remembrance” (Ṭā Hā 20:14). Allah gave him two signs, the staff that became a snake and the hand that shone white, and sent him to Pharaoh. Mūsā asked for help:

> رَبِّ اشْرَحْ لِي صَدْرِي ﴿٢٥﴾ وَيَسِّرْ لِي أَمْرِي ﴿٢٦﴾
> وَاحْلُلْ عُقْدَةً مِّن لِّسَانِي ﴿٢٧﴾ يَفْقَهُوا قَوْلِي
>
> **“My Lord, expand my chest for me, ease my task for me, and untie the knot from my tongue, so they may understand my speech.”**
>
> Ṭā Hā 20:25–28. He asked for his brother Hārūn as a helper, and Allah granted it (20:29–36).

Allah told them to speak to Pharaoh, the greatest tyrant of his time, “with gentle speech, so that perhaps he may remember or fear” (Ṭā Hā 20:44).

Mūsā, Pharaoh and the magicians

Pharaoh rejected the signs, claimed “I am your lord, most high” (an-Nāziʿāt 79:24), and gathered the best magicians of Egypt for a public contest. When they threw their ropes and staffs, they seemed to move. Mūsā threw his staff, and it swallowed what they had made. The magicians fell down in prostration and said: “We believe in the Lord of Hārūn and Mūsā” (Ṭā Hā 20:70). Pharaoh threatened to cut off their hands and feet and crucify them, and they replied: “Decide whatever you will; you can only decide for this worldly life” (20:72).

The parting of the sea

After years of signs and warnings, Allah commanded Mūsā to leave Egypt by night with the Children of Israel. Pharaoh pursued them with his army. When they reached the sea, the people cried: “We will surely be overtaken!” Mūsā answered:

> قَالَ كَلَّا ۖ إِنَّ مَعِيَ رَبِّي سَيَهْدِينِ
>
> **“No! Indeed, my Lord is with me; He will guide me.”**
>
> Ash-Shuʿarāʾ 26:62. Allah told him to strike the sea with his staff, and it parted, each side like a great mountain (26:63). The believers crossed, and Pharaoh and his army were drowned.

As he drowned, Pharaoh declared belief, but it was too late. Allah said: “Today We will preserve your body so that you may be a sign for those who come after you” (Yūnus 10:90–92). The Prophet

ﷺ fasted the day of ʿĀshūrāʾ and told the Muslims to fast it, because it was the day Allah saved Mūsā (al-Bukhārī, 2004).

Trials with his own people

Mūsā's patience with the Children of Israel was perhaps an even greater test. While he was away for forty nights at his appointment with his Lord, where he received the Tawrāh on tablets (al-Aʿrāf 7:142–145), as-Sāmirī led them to worship a golden calf (Ṭā Hā 20:85–97). When commanded to enter the Holy Land, they said: "Go, you and your Lord, and fight; we are staying right here" (al-Māʾidah 5:24), and were made to wander for forty years (5:26). The Prophet ﷺ, when he was hurt by people, would say: "May Allah have mercy on Mūsā; he was harmed with more than this, and he was patient" (al-Bukhārī, 3150).

Mūsā and al-Khiḍr

Once, Mūsā said that he was the most knowledgeable person, and Allah told him that a servant of His at the junction of the two seas had knowledge he did not have (al-Bukhārī, 122). Mūsā travelled to learn from him, and the Qur'an tells of their journey: the boat, the boy and the wall, and the wisdom hidden behind events that seemed wrong (al-Kahf 18:60–82).

Lessons for us

1	**Allah's plan works through what seems like danger**: a baby in a river ended up in Pharaoh's palace, nursed by his own mother.
2	**Turn to Allah in need**: "My Lord, I am in need of whatever good You send down to me."
3	**Speak gently, even to tyrants**, and ask Allah to ease your task and your speech.
4	**Certainty in Allah when there seems to be no way out**: "My Lord is with me; He will guide me."
5	**Keep learning, however much you know**, as Mūsā travelled to learn from al-Khiḍr.

04

ŪLU AL-ʿAZM · 04

عِيسَى ابْنُ مَرْيَمَ

KALIMATULLĀH · A WORD FROM ALLAH

ʿĪsā

ʿĪsā ibn Maryam, peace be upon him

Sent to the Children of Israel · Palestine

19
Sūrat Maryam, named after his mother

2
comings: his mission, and his return before the Hour

1
message: worship Allah alone (al-Mā'idah 5:117)

Messenger 4 ʿĪsā ibn Maryam: at a glance

Titles	The Messiah (al-Masīḥ); “a word from Allah” and “a spirit from Him” (an-Nisāʾ 4:171); the servant and messenger of Allah
Sent to	The Children of Israel
Scripture	The Injīl
Mother	Maryam bint ʿImrān, chosen by Allah above the women of the worlds (Āl ʿImrān 3:42); a whole sūrah is named after her
Signs	Born without a father; spoke in the cradle; by Allah’s permission healed the blind and the leper and brought the dead to life
End of his mission	Not killed nor crucified, but raised by Allah; he will return before the Hour

Maryam

ʿĪsā’s story begins with his grandmother, the wife of ʿImrān, who vowed her unborn child to Allah’s service (Āl ʿImrān 3:35). The child was Maryam, and Allah accepted her with a beautiful acceptance and placed her in the care of the prophet Zakariyyā. Whenever he entered her prayer chamber, he found provision with her, and she said: “It is from Allah” (3:37).

His miraculous birth

The angel came to Maryam with news of a son. She asked how she could have a child when no man had touched her, and was told: “Thus Allah creates what He wills. When He decrees a matter, He only says to it ‘Be’, and it is” (Āl ʿImrān 3:47). In the pains of childbirth beneath a palm tree, she was told to shake its trunk for fresh dates and drink from a stream beneath her (Maryam 19:23–26). When she came to her people carrying the baby and they accused her, she pointed to him, and he spoke from the cradle:

> قَالَ إِنِّي عَبْدُ اللَّهِ آتَانِيَ الْكِتَابَ وَجَعَلَنِي نَبِيًّا
>
> **“He said: Indeed, I am the servant of Allah. He has given me the Scripture and made me a prophet.”**
>
> Maryam 19:30. The first thing he said was that he is the servant of Allah.

إِنَّ مَثَلَ عِيسَىٰ عِندَ اللَّهِ كَمَثَلِ آدَمَ ۖ خَلَقَهُ مِن تُرَابٍ ثُمَّ قَالَ لَهُ كُن فَيَكُونُ

“Indeed, the example of ʿĪsā with Allah is like that of Ādam: He created him from dust, then said to him ‘Be’, and he was.”

Āl ʿImrān 3:59.

His signs and his message

Allah supported ʿĪsā with clear signs, each one “by the permission of Allah”: he formed the shape of a bird from clay and breathed into it and it became a bird, he healed the blind and the leper, he brought the dead to life, and he told people what they ate and stored in their houses (Āl ʿImrān 3:49; al-Māʾidah 5:110). His disciples (al-Ḥawāriyyūn) answered his call: “We are the helpers of Allah” (aṣ-Ṣaff 61:14). He confirmed the Tawrāh, made lawful some of what had been forbidden to them, and gave glad tidings of the final messenger:

وَمُبَشِّرًا بِرَسُولٍ يَأْتِي مِن بَعْدِي اسْمُهُ أَحْمَدُ

“…and bringing good tidings of a messenger to come after me, whose name is Aḥmad.”

Aṣ-Ṣaff 61:6.

ʿĪsā never claimed to be divine. On the Day of Judgement, Allah will ask him whether he told people to take him and his mother as gods, and he will say: “I only said to them what You commanded me: Worship Allah, my Lord and your Lord” (al-Māʾidah 5:116–117).

Raised, not crucified

His enemies plotted to kill him, but Allah saved him:

وَمَا قَتَلُوهُ وَمَا صَلَبُوهُ وَلَٰكِن شُبِّهَ لَهُمْ

“They did not kill him, nor did they crucify him, but it was made to appear so to them.”

An-Nisāʾ 4:157. “Rather, Allah raised him to Himself” (4:158).

His return

The Prophet ﷺ said: “By the One in whose hand is my soul, the son of Maryam will soon descend among you as a just judge. He will break the cross, kill the pig and abolish the jizyah” (al-Bukhārī 2222, Muslim 155), meaning he will rule by the Sharīʿah of Muḥammad ﷺ. He will kill the Dajjāl (Muslim, 2937). The Prophet ﷺ said: “I am the closest of people to ʿĪsā son of Maryam in this world and the Hereafter; there was no prophet between me and him” (al-Bukhārī, 3442).

Lessons for us

1	**Muslims love and honour ʿĪsā and his mother**; believing in him is part of our faith.
2	**Tawḥīd is the heart of his message**: his first words were “I am the servant of Allah.”
3	**Every miracle is by Allah’s permission**; power belongs to Allah alone.
4	**Raise children for Allah**, as Maryam’s mother vowed her child to Him.
5	**Trust Allah in hardship**: Maryam was given food and water at her most difficult moment.

05

ŪLU AL-ʿAZM · 05

مُحَمَّدٌ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ ﷺ

KHĀTAM AN-NABIYYĪN · THE SEAL OF THE PROPHETS

Muḥammad ﷺ

Muḥammad ibn ʿAbdillāh ﷺ

The Seal of the Prophets, sent to all mankind · Makkah and Madinah

63	23	1
years, the length of his life	years of revelation	final message for all mankind

Messenger 5 Muḥammad ﷺ: at a glance

Titles	**Khātam an-Nabiyyīn**, the Seal of the Prophets (al-Aḥzāb 33:40); a mercy to the worlds (al-Anbiyāʾ 21:107)
Sent to	All mankind and the jinn, until the Day of Judgement (Sabaʾ 34:28)
Scripture	The Qur'an
Born	In Makkah in the Year of the Elephant (around 570 CE)
Revelation	At forty, in the Cave of Ḥirāʾ (around 610 CE); 13 years in Makkah, 10 in Madinah
Died	12 Rabīʿ al-Awwal 11 AH (632 CE) in Madinah, aged 63

The answer to Ibrāhīm's duʿāʾ

Ibrāhīm prayed for a messenger from among his descendants in Makkah (al-Baqarah 2:129), and ʿĪsā gave glad tidings of a messenger named Aḥmad (aṣ-Ṣaff 61:6). The Prophet ﷺ said of himself that he was "the duʿāʾ of my father Ibrāhīm and the glad tidings of ʿĪsā" (reported by Aḥmad and graded authentic by many scholars). He was born an orphan in Makkah, raised by his grandfather and then his uncle, and known even before Prophethood as **al-Amīn**, the trustworthy.

Thirteen years of patience in Makkah

When the revelation came, he called his people to worship Allah alone, and they responded with mockery, insults, torture of his followers, a three-year boycott that left the Muslims starving in a valley, and plots to kill him. In one year he lost both his wife Khadījah and his uncle Abū Ṭālib. He went to aṭ-Ṭāʾif to call its people, and they stoned him until his feet bled.

ʿĀʾishah once asked him whether he had faced a day harder than Uḥud. He told her of aṭ-Ṭāʾif. On his way back, the angel of the mountains came and offered to crush the people between the two mountains of Makkah. He said:

> بَلْ أَرْجُو أَنْ يُخْرِجَ اللَّهُ مِنْ أَصْلَابِهِمْ مَنْ يَعْبُدُ اللَّهَ وَحْدَهُ لَا يُشْرِكُ بِهِ شَيْئًا
>
> **"Rather, I hope that Allah will bring from their descendants people who will worship Allah alone, associating nothing with Him."**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3231) and Muslim (1795).

The Hijrah and the years in Madinah

In 622 CE he emigrated to Madinah, where he built a community: the mosque, brotherhood between the Muhājirūn and the Anṣār, and a covenant among the city's people. He faced the attacks of Quraysh at Badr, Uḥud and the Trench, made the treaty of al-Ḥudaybiyah, and in 8 AH entered Makkah with ten thousand believers. He forgave the people who had persecuted him for twenty years and cleansed the Kaʿbah of idols, restoring the House of Ibrāhīm to the worship of Allah alone.

At his Farewell Ḥajj in 10 AH, on the day of ʿArafah, Allah revealed: "This day I have perfected for you your religion, completed My favour upon you, and approved for you Islām as religion" (al-Māʾidah 5:3; al-Bukhārī, 45). A few months later he fell ill, and died in the house of ʿĀʾishah. His last words were: "O Allah, the Highest Companion" (al-Bukhārī, 4463).

The Seal of the Prophets

مَثَلِي وَمَثَلُ الْأَنْبِيَاءِ مِنْ قَبْلِي كَمَثَلِ رَجُلٍ بَنَى بَيْتًا فَأَحْسَنَهُ وَأَجْمَلَهُ، إِلَّا مَوْضِعَ لَبِنَةٍ مِنْ زَاوِيَةٍ... فَأَنَا اللَّبِنَةُ، وَأَنَا خَاتَمُ النَّبِيِّينَ

"My example and the example of the prophets before me is that of a man who built a house and made it fine and beautiful, except for the place of one brick in a corner. People walked around it, admiring it and saying: If only this brick were put in place! I am that brick, and I am the Seal of the Prophets."

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3535) and Muslim (2286).

Allah described him: "And indeed, you are of a great moral character" (al-Qalam 68:4).

Lessons for us

1	**Mercy even to enemies.** At aṭ-Ṭāʾif he hoped for their descendants' guidance rather than their destruction.
2	**Patience is the path**: thirteen years in Makkah before the Hijrah, and Allah told him to be patient like the messengers before him.
3	**Forgive when you are able**, as he did on the day Makkah was opened.
4	**He completed the building of the prophets.** To love him is to love them all, and to follow him is to follow their one religion.

Part 7 What they share

	Nūḥ	Ibrāhīm	Mūsā	ʿĪsā	Muḥammad ﷺ
Title	Grateful servant	Friend of Allah	Spoken to by Allah	A word from Allah	Seal of the Prophets
Sent to	His people	His people	Pharaoh and Banū Isrāʾīl	Banū Isrāʾīl	All mankind and jinn
Scripture	Not named	Ṣuḥuf	Tawrāh	Injīl	Qur’an
Greatest trial	Centuries of rejection	The fire and the sacrifice	Pharaoh and his own people	Plots to kill him	Persecution, exile and war
Sign	The ark	The fire made cool	The staff and the sea	Birth and healing	The Qur’an
Family test	Son and wife disbelieved	Father disbelieved	Raised in Pharaoh’s house	Mother slandered	Uncle Abū Lahab opposed him

The same message

وَلَقَدْ بَعَثْنَا فِي كُلِّ أُمَّةٍ رَّسُولًا أَنِ اعْبُدُوا اللَّهَ وَاجْتَنِبُوا الطَّاغُوتَ

“And We certainly sent to every nation a messenger, [saying]: Worship Allah and avoid false gods.”

An-Naḥl 16:36.

Every one of the five began with tawḥīd. Each faced people who preferred the ways of their forefathers, and each met mockery with patience, harm with forgiveness, and fear with trust in Allah. The Prophet ﷺ said: “The people most severely tested are the prophets, then the next best, then the next best” (at-Tirmidhī 2398, ḥasan ṣaḥīḥ). Their trials were not a sign of Allah’s anger but of their rank.

Du‘ā’s The du‘ā’s of Ūlu al-‘Azm

Memorise one du‘ā’ from each messenger and use it in your own prayers.

Nūḥ

رَّبِّ اغْفِرْ لِي وَلِوَالِدَيَّ وَلِمَن دَخَلَ بَيْتِيَ مُؤْمِنًا وَلِلْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَالْمُؤْمِنَاتِ

“My Lord, forgive me, my parents, whoever enters my house a believer, and the believing men and believing women.”

Nūḥ 71:28

Ibrāhīm

رَبِّ اجْعَلْنِي مُقِيمَ الصَّلَاةِ وَمِن ذُرِّيَّتِي ۚ رَبَّنَا وَتَقَبَّلْ دُعَاءِ

“My Lord, make me an establisher of prayer, and from my descendants. Our Lord, and accept my supplication.”

Ibrāhīm 14:40

Mūsā

رَبِّ اشْرَحْ لِي صَدْرِي ﴿٢٥﴾ وَيَسِّرْ لِي أَمْرِي

“My Lord, expand my chest for me, and ease my task for me.”

Ṭā Hā 20:25–26

ʿĪsā

إِن تُعَذِّبْهُمْ فَإِنَّهُمْ عِبَادُكَ ۖ وَإِن تَغْفِرْ لَهُمْ فَإِنَّكَ أَنتَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ

“If You punish them, they are Your servants; and if You forgive them, You are the Almighty, the Wise.”

Al-Māʾidah 5:118. The Prophet ﷺ once recited this verse all night in prayer, weeping for his Ummah (an-Nasāʾī, 1010).

Muḥammad ﷺ

رَبَّنَا آتِنَا فِي الدُّنْيَا حَسَنَةً وَفِي الْآخِرَةِ حَسَنَةً وَقِنَا عَذَابَ النَّارِ

“Our Lord, give us good in this world and good in the Hereafter, and protect us from the punishment of the Fire.”

Al-Baqarah 2:201. The duʿāʾ the Prophet ﷺ made most often (al-Bukhārī, 6389).

Part 8 Lessons for today

What Ūlu al-ʿAzm teach us

1	**Begin with tawḥīd.** Every messenger started by calling to the worship of Allah alone.
2	**Patience is not passive.** They kept working, calling and building while they waited for Allah's help.
3	**Family is a trust, not a guarantee.** Nūḥ's son and Ibrāhīm's father were not saved by being related to a prophet; Ismāʿīl and Maryam show the fruit of a righteous upbringing.
4	**Speak with gentleness and wisdom**, even to tyrants and to those who harm you.
5	**Trust Allah when there seems to be no way out**: the fire, the sea, the valley of Makkah, the cave.
6	**Love all the prophets.** A Muslim believes in all of them and makes no distinction between them in belief (al-Baqarah 2:285).

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers are on the next page.

1. Which verse commands the Prophet ﷺ to be patient like Ūlu al-ʿAzm?

a) Al-Aḥqāf 46:35 b) Al-Fātiḥah 1:5 c) Al-Ikhlāṣ 112:1 d) An-Nās 114:1

2. How long did Nūḥ call his people?

a) 40 years b) 100 years c) 950 years d) 23 years

3. What does "Ūlu al-ʿAzm" mean?

a) Those of firm resolve b) Those of great wealth c) Those of noble birth d) Those who wrote books

4. Who did Nūḥ call to board the ark, but who refused?

a) His son b) His father c) His brother d) His neighbour

5. Ibrāhīm is called:

a) Kalīmullāh b) Khalīlullāh c) Rūḥullāh d) Khātam an-Nabiyyīn

6. What did Allah say to the fire?

a) "Be coolness and safety upon Ibrāhīm" b) "Burn brightly" c) "Go out" d) "Rise higher"

7. Hājar said, when she learned Allah had commanded it:

a) "Then He will not abandon us" b) "Take us with you" c) "We will return to Iraq" d) "Leave us food"

8. Mūsā was raised in the house of:

a) Pharaoh b) Zakariyyā c) His uncle d) A shepherd

9. What did Mūsā say when the people cried "We will be overtaken"?

a) "My Lord is with me; He will guide me" b) "Let us surrender" c) "Go back to Egypt" d) "Fight them"

10. Which day did the Prophet ﷺ fast because Allah saved Mūsā on it?

a) ʿĀshūrāʾ b) ʿArafah c) The 15th of Shaʿbān d) Monday

11. The first words of ʿĪsā in the cradle were:

a) "I am the servant of Allah" b) "I am the son of Allah" c) "My mother is innocent" d) "Peace be upon you"

12. According to the Qur'an, ʿĪsā was:

a) Neither killed nor crucified, but raised b) Crucified and buried c) Killed by the Romans d) Died of old age

13. ʿĪsā gave glad tidings of a messenger named:

a) Aḥmad b) Yaḥyā c) Zakariyyā d) Isḥāq

14. In the ḥadīth of the house, the Prophet ﷺ described himself as:

a) The missing brick b) The door c) The roof d) The foundation

15. What did the Prophet ﷺ say to the angel of the mountains after aṭ-Ṭāʾif?

a) He hoped their descendants would worship Allah b) Crush them c) Wait a year d) Punish their leaders

Answers Answers and reflection

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	a) Al-Aḥqāf 46:35	9	a) “My Lord is with me…”
2	c) 950 years	10	a) ʿĀshūrāʾ
3	a) Those of firm resolve	11	a) “I am the servant of Allah”
4	a) His son	12	a) Neither killed nor crucified, but raised
5	b) Khalīlullāh	13	a) Aḥmad
6	a) “Be coolness and safety…”	14	a) The missing brick
7	a) “Then He will not abandon us”	15	a) He hoped for their descendants’ guidance
8	a) Pharaoh		

Activities

1 Which messenger’s patience speaks most to your own life right now, and why?

.....

.....

.....

2 Which duʿāʾ of the five will you memorise first? Write it here in Arabic.

.....

.....

.....

3 Tell the story of one messenger to a younger sibling or friend this week. What did they ask you?

.....

.....

.....

Glossary Words to know

Term	Meaning
Nabī and Rasūl	A prophet receives revelation; a messenger is a prophet sent with a message to deliver to a people. Every messenger is a prophet.
Ūlu al-ʿAzm	The messengers of firm resolve: Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, ʿĪsā and Muḥammad ﷺ.
Tawḥīd	Worshipping Allah alone, without partners.
Ṭāghūt	Anything worshipped or obeyed besides Allah.
Ṣuḥuf	Scrolls; the scriptures given to Ibrāhīm (and Mūsā).
Tawrāh and Injīl	The scriptures revealed to Mūsā and to ʿĪsā.
Khalīl	The closest friend; Ibrāhīm is Khalīlullāh.
Kalīm	One spoken to; Mūsā is Kalīmullāh.
Al-Masīḥ	The Messiah: a title of ʿĪsā.
Al-Ḥawāriyyūn	The disciples of ʿĪsā.
Isrāʾīliyyāt	Reports taken from the People of the Book, not relied on unless confirmed by the Qur'an and Sunnah.
Khātam an-Nabiyyīn	The Seal of the Prophets: there is no prophet after Muḥammad ﷺ.

For further reading

- **Qaṣaṣ al-Anbiyāʾ** (Stories of the Prophets), Ibn Kathīr, available in English.
- **Tafsīr Ibn Kathīr**, at the verses mentioned in each chapter.
- **ar-Raḥīq al-Makhtūm** (The Sealed Nectar), Ṣafiyyur-Raḥmān al-Mubārakpūrī, on the life of the Prophet ﷺ.
- Sūrat Nūḥ, Sūrat Ibrāhīm, Sūrat al-Qaṣaṣ and Sūrat Maryam: read them in one sitting each, with a translation.

Du‘ā’ Belief in all the messengers

آمَنَ الرَّسُولُ بِمَا أُنزِلَ إِلَيْهِ مِن رَّبِّهِ وَالْمُؤْمِنُونَ ۚ كُلٌّ آمَنَ بِاللَّهِ وَمَلَائِكَتِهِ وَكُتُبِهِ وَرُسُلِهِ لَا نُفَرِّقُ بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِّن رُّسُلِهِ

“The Messenger has believed in what was revealed to him from his Lord, and so have the believers. All of them have believed in Allah, His angels, His books and His messengers: we make no distinction between any of His messengers.”

Al-Baqarah 2:285.

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- A comparison table, lessons for today and a self-test

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